BEFORE

By around 3000 BCE trading centers were developing in the eastern Mediterranean, the Arab peninsula, and Nubia.

MEDITERRANEAN MARITIME CITIES

By *c.* 3000 BCE, the maritime cities that would become the heartland of "Phoenician" (a later Greek label) civilization were developing or well established along the eastern Mediterranean coast. These included the cities of Tyre, Byblos, and Sidon (all in modern Lebanon).

THE ARABS

During the 3rd millennium BCE, states were flourishing in the better-watered parts of the Arabian peninsula. The "Magan" area (modern Oman) was an important trade partner for Mesopotamia « 54–55. Magan was valued for its **copper and diorite**, while it received goods such as textiles and wool.


IVORY COMB, EGYPT'S OLD KINGDOM

NUBIA

Also during the 3rd millennium BCE, Nubia (modern Sudan) was forging links with Egypt by trading goods, providing a corridor to Africa through which Egypt obtained **ebony, ivory, gold, incense, and exotic animals**.

Conquering Sea and Desert

During the 2nd millennium BCE, a variety of peoples in coastal and desert areas fringing more populated regions established vital trading networks that linked a cross-section of cultures.

Tyre, Byblos, and Sidon formed the core of a great maritime trading network. These city-states on the east Mediterranean coast, a region known as Canaan in the 2nd millennium BCE and as Phoenicia to the Greeks, prospered between 1200–600 BCE.

The Phoenicians used maritime trade to expand a relatively small land base and keep at bay powers looking to control them. These included Egypt and the Hittites, from whose dominance Phoenicia emerged around 1200 BCE, and the ancient Greeks.

The Phoenicians' extraordinary seafaring prowess made them the control center for routes crossing the Mediterranean. Their trading links extended to Mesopotamia and, through the Red Sea, to Arabia and Africa. They were also successful merchants and manufacturers, supplying a range of goods—from rich, exotic fabrics and glass to cedar wood—that found a lucrative market in Assyria.

A vast network of trading posts included Carthage in North Africa and Gades (Cadiz) in Iberia (Spain), close to the centers of tin production. Trade made Phoenicia an important force in international cultural exchange and spread the influential writing system that they developed (see pp.62–63).

The "Phoenicians," as the Greeks called them, are the same as the "Canaanites"; while the port of Ugarit (see p.79) was abandoned in the course of the collapse of the Late Bronze Age system, most other Canaanite cities survived intact and formed close trading links with the Philistines and other new arrivals.

Arab trade

Important trading networks were also established in the Arab world at this time. By the late 9th century BCE, there were major centers in southern Arabia (modern Yemen), including the Minaean and Sabaean kingdoms, and in the north. The lives of the seminomadic Arabs were transformed by the domestication of the camel, around the 12th century BCE. This made it easier to create settlements in the desert, based around large oases, and to travel across arid regions in search of new resources.

Secrets of the desert

Camel trails marked out routes that became part of an "Incense Road," carrying incense and spices. Only the Arabs knew the secrets of traversing their dangerous desert routes. This knowledge made them powerful and wealthy, and they did their best to shroud their trails and sources in fabulous myth.

The Kingdom of Kush

A valuable nexus of trade routes was also thriving farther west, around the kingdom of Kush, in southern Nubia, bringing precious materials such as ivory and gold to the ancient world. By the 8th century BCE, Kush and its capital, Napata, were enjoying a glorious period as a major trade center freed from Egyptian domination. The value of Nubia's trade routes was one of the main reasons why Egypt had worked so hard, from about 2000 BCE, to exert control here, and the two cultures had a lasting impact on each other.

The earliest archaeological evidence for the Phoenician colony at Carthage dates to the second half of the 8th century BCE. Traditionally, the date of this trading post is given as 814 BCE.

This stone slab (stela) from the Amun temple at Kawa shows a Nubian king called Ary, who may be the 8th-century BCE founder of the "kingdom of Kush" (in Egypt and Sudan), worshipping the gods Amun, Mut, and Khonsu.

Trade across the desert and sea All manner of goods, from many different sources, were transported across huge distances by networks that meshed Phoenician-controlled routes with the trade routes of Mediterranean, Middle Eastern, African, and Arabian peoples. For example, the 14th-century-BCE ship found wrecked off Uluburun (modern Turkey) was carrying goods from Mycenae, Canaan, Egypt, and Assyria. Its "nationality" is uncertain.

HOW WE KNOW

THE INCENSE TRADE

Since ancient times, tales circulated about a "lost city" on the Arabian peninsula. Archaeological discoveries in the 1980s and 1990s, using images taken from space, appear to have found this city and identified it as Ubar (a region, not a city), in modern Oman. Items unearthed there include frankincense burners, and it is thought that this was a major Arabian trading post on the incense route, probably thriving by 900 BCE.

Incense was so precious, and its trade so important, because it masked unpleasant smells and was used in religious ceremonies. The trees from which aromatic resins are obtained grow only in Oman. This is why the incense, gold, and myrrh brought to Jesus by the three kings were such special gifts.


INCENSE BURNER